skiing. "I was a good fit since mountaineering had helped me build endurance. A few weeks later, I was taking part in my first competition. And at the Khelo India Winter Games in March 2020, I picked up two bronze medals," says Bhavani. It gave her enough encouragement to give the sport a serious thought.

During the COVID-19 pandemic, Bhavani worked on both strength and endurance. With most facilities shut down, she worked with tyres and bricks at a makeshift gym back home in Peroor in Karnataka. At the next edition of the Winter Games, she picked up her first gold, finishing ahead of even the experienced ITBP athletes, who had not participated in 2020.

"I told my parents that I wanted to give the sport a shot. It's an expensive affair and my father had to take loans against our property," says Bhavani, who quit her job as a ski instructor to focus on the sport, and dug into her savings to buy equipment and fund travel.

Last year, she trained for close to two months in Norway and competed at her first International Ski Federation (FIS) event in Iceland. Though she missed out on a podium finish, it helped her qualify for the FIS Nordic World Ski Championships in Slovenia in February.

Funding has been a constant issue. Through Olympian Shiva Kesavan, she landed a training stint in Italy this winter. The immediate target is another competition in Iceland before the World Championships. But beyond that, she has set her mind on competing at the 2026 Winter Olympics. "It's not just about competing at the Olympics. I want to change things for the next generation of winter sports athletes in India," she says. ■

Shail Desai





SPORTS

Coming Into His Own

For H.S. Prannoy, 2022 was a standout year. Going ahead, the World No. 8 shuttler eyes more podium finishes

Some may call H.S. Prannoy a 'late bloomer'. At 30, he had a standout 2022, as he played an instrumental role in India's maiden Thomas Cup title, a team event equivalent to the World Cup in men's badminton. It's one of the many feathers in Prannoy's cap last year, which also saw him make it to a final, two semifinals and seven quarterfinals and achieve a career-high world ranking of eight besides earning a nomination for the Most Improved Player by the Badminton World Federation. "For me, 2022 was definitely better than the last few years when there were no big results and I lacked consistency," says the shuttler. "Playing more matches and being on the court for a much longer time gave me a lot of confidence."

PRANNOY BEGINS HIS CAMPAIGN AT THE INDIA OPEN WITH A TOUGH FIRST-ROUND CONTEST AGAINST LAKSHYA SEN

But for those who keenly follow the badminton circuit, this Keralite—a silver medallist at the Youth Olympics and a World Junior bronze medallist in 2010—was finally living up to the promise he showed early on. Injuries hampered his rise in seniors and the shuttler has been candid about his struggle to stay motivated amid professional setbacks. "You doubt yourself," he says. "I'd even told my parents that I'm done with the sport." What helped was a close circle of friends, and coach Pullela Gopcihand and his peers at the academy in Hyderabad. "Certain people trust you more than you trust yourself," he adds. "Without them, I wouldn't have made it to this level."

Though an individual title eluded him in 2022, Prannoy takes positives from the journey. So what changes did he make in his approach to get the results and stay injury-free? "In a very tightly packed calendar, it is necessary to understand that your body is your first priority," he says. A carefully curated calendar ensured he didn't wear out, and a leaner body helped with both movement and endurance.

In 2023, he'd like the consistency to lead to more podium finishes, hopefully, some on the top. "The work is always being done, but a lot of things have to fall into place and you have to trust the process," he says. "I hope it happens soon." Prannoy begins his campaign at the upcoming India Open (January 17-22) with a tough first-round contest against his compatriot and defending champion Lakshya Sen. Playing in front of the home crowd is always special, but this year's tournament is an upgraded affair with top players arriving at New Delhi. "This would definitely be a big boost for Indian badminton," says Prannoy, "and a treat for all badminton fans." ■

Suhani Singh